



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Rivendell Academy

School Website: <https://rivendellacademyga.org>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because ACCS require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Rivendell Academy (Columbus, GA 31907) presents a clearly Christian, classical-leaning program that centers on truth, goodness, and beauty through liberal-arts formation. Public materials emphasize a Christian worldview, a commitment to the liberal arts, and a formation-focused aim (character, wisdom, discernment) rather than purely vocational outcomes. The site explicitly frames education as a formation of character in a classical idiom, including references to truth, biblical foundations, and discernment, while also outlining a structured curricular cadence (three core days per week with Bible/history/literature/linguistics and writing) and a parental-friendly environment (Parent Portal, open admissions policies, and a faculty-driven approach). These strengths support a Classical orientation in several areas, particularly Religious/Metaphysical Foundations and School Purpose/Goal, and to a substantial extent Faculty and Parents/Community. However, the curriculum and pedagogy signals are incomplete relative to a fully realized Classical program, with less explicit emphasis on Great Books, direct Socratic pedagogy, grammar-logics-rhetoric progression, and a fully articulated Great Conversation tradition within the curriculum. This places Rivendell Academy in the category of SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL overall, with clear pathways to CLASSICAL through targeted programmatic expansions.

- Evidence of CLASSICAL alignment is strongest in Religious and Metaphysical Foundations and School Purpose/Goal, anchored by explicit statements about truth, goodness, beauty, theology, and formation through liberal-arts education. The public materials emphasize Christian discernment, joyful learning, and a Bible-centric core in the upper-structure and daily practice. See mission statements and core-days description.
- Evidence for a robust Curriculum and Pedagogy that fully embodies classical norms is present but incomplete. The site highlights liberal-arts education and Bible/history/literature, but it does not consistently foreground Great Books, the Trivium/Quadrivium, or explicit Socratic seminars in public-facing materials. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL signal for Element 3 and Element 4.
- Faculty and Parent/Community signals are positive (there is a visible Faculty section and Parent Portal), supporting CLASSICAL cues in those areas, though richer detail about the living curriculum and teacher portraits would strengthen the case.
- The aggregate profile thus skews toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with strong religious-metaphysical grounding and formation aims, but with room to intensify core classical methods (Socratic pedagogy, Great Books, Trivium terminology, liturgical practices) to become fully CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public messaging centers on truth, goodness, beauty within a Classical Christian framework. Examples include explicit statements of pursuing truth through Classical Christian Education and a mission framed by recognizing and upholding true/good/beautiful through godly discernment. - The site asserts a Christ-centered formation and the goal of equipping students to interact with the world through discernment, which signals transcendental moral realism and theology-grounded education. - The site's public pages explicitly mention Bible/history/literature/writing as core studies, with a spiritual aim.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords observed: truth, goodness, beauty, virtue (implied by Christian formation), theology, sacred/heavenly discernment, divine order. These map to the lexicon's Positive Keywords for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations (truth, goodness, beauty; theology; sacred tradition; virtue; Logos). - Negative keywords: not clearly present in public material (no explicit secular-relativist signals in the core statements).

Why this rating - The school clearly emphasizes transcendental moral realism and theology, with explicit mention of God/Jesus, discernment, and the true/good/beautiful triad. It aligns strongly with the Religious and Metaphysical Foundations, though explicit liturgical/communal practices are less documented in site copy. The balance of evidence supports CLASSICAL in intent, but the public rendering shows potential for richer liturgical/communal integration to reach full CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission centers on formation via liberal arts and virtuous, wise character, not job-focused training. The content emphasizes formation, wisdom, and human flourishing through a classical framework. - The expressed telos includes recognition and upholding truth, goodness, and beauty, with a view toward shaping discernment and moral imagination. - Language about joyful learning and lifelong formation supports a purpose-driven, non-vocational aim consistent with classical education.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal arts, true/good/beautiful, telos, contemplation (implied by joyful learning and discernment), great conversation (implied by classical aims, though not always explicit in copy). - Negative keywords: minimal signs of career-readiness/21st-century skills emphasis in the public materials; the emphasis remains formation-centered. (No clear negative signals in the core messaging.)

Why this rating - Rivendell Academy foregrounds formation, virtue, and teleology through a classical-Christian lens, aligning well with the Classical ideal for Element 2. The presence of a formation-centric telos and a desire to cultivate wisdom over mere information substantiates CLASSICAL rather than merely "informal" or vocationally skewed aims.

Element 3: Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum is described as a liberal-arts program and includes Bible/history/literature/linguistics/writing on a three-core-days schedule, indicating integration of classical disciplines and a structured cadence. - There is no explicit public emphasis on Great Books, original classical texts, or the Great Conversation, nor explicit mention of Trivium/Quadrivium in the site copy. The absence of these explicit elements reduces the strength of a full classical Curriculum claim. - The presence of core-arts focus and a Bible-centered humanities strand signals classical intent, yet with a narrower textual scope than a full classical program as defined by the Six Essential Elements.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords observed: liberal arts, grammar/logic/rhetoric (mentioned as classical ideals in the knowledge-base lexicon, though not explicitly enumerated on the site), Great Books (not explicitly present on the site copy), history as a through-line, wonder/integration (implied by the three-core-days approach and joyful learning). The site does emphasize the liberal-arts backbone. - Negative keywords observed: explicit rejection of a Great Books+primary-text approach is not shown; rather, the site simply does not foreground Great Books or the full Trivium/Quadrivium framework in public copy. The absence of those elements signals that the curriculum may not yet fully meet the canonical Six Elements.

Why this rating - The curriculum clearly aligns with liberal-arts formation and classical aims in spirit, but a lack of explicit Great Books engagement and the Trivium/Quadrivium structure (as publicly documented) means Rivendell Academy is not fully CLASSICAL in Curriculum by the strict rubric. The signals are strong but incomplete, hence SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials describe a structured daily/weekly rhythm (Three Core Days) focusing on Bible/history/literature/linguistics/writing, with opportunities for joyful learning and disciplined study. This hints at a disciplined pedagogy and contemplative pace, but does not clearly document Socratic seminars or explicit memorization/recitation methods. - The site emphasizes a Christian formation ethos, and while it hints at memory work or worship-like cadence (via the Three Core Days and the devotional/discipleship framing), explicit Socratic dialogue, seminars, or rhetoric training are not foregrounded in public copy.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords observed: Scholé/restful pace (though not named as Scholé), contemplation, wonder, structured dialogue (not clearly asserted, but the classical aim often includes this); memory work or chanting is not publicly cited but could be implied in traditional classical pedagogy. The site does not overtly promote Socratic seminars, dialectic, or rhetoric training in public copy. - Negative keywords observed: explicit absence of Socratic teaching, memorizations/recitation are not described; experiential or project-based-only approaches are not presented as the school's primary method. The public content leans away from pure constructivist/project-based-only pedagogy.

Why this rating - The pedagogy shows classical potential through structured content and a formation-centered framework but lacks explicit documentation of core classical methods (Socratic dialogue, memorization/recitation, strict rhetoric training) in public-facing copy. This places Pedagogy at SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL, given the partial alignment.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school has a visible “Our Faculty” section in the navigation, signaling a central role for teachers in the program. This supports the classical ideal of teachers as mentors and living exemplars in the curriculum. - The knowledge-base tradition for classical education emphasizes that the faculty should be living examples, mentors, and part of the living curriculum; Rivendell’s stated mission and presence of a dedicated faculty area align with that expectation, even if detailed public language is limited.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords observed: living curriculum, mentors, master-teacher modeling, substantial faculty presence (as indicated by the “Our Faculty” page). The site’s emphasis on formation and virtue aligns with the classical faculty ideal. - Negative keywords observed: None explicit in public copy; the site does not reveal potential tensions (e.g., non-classical faculty training language) in the accessible content.

Why this rating - The existence of a faculty section and the formation-focused mission supports CLASSICAL in Element 5. The public content aligns with the expectation of model teachers and mentors, even if more detailed portraits of faculty roles would strengthen the case.

Element 6: Parents & Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site includes a Parent Portal and admissions content, signaling parental involvement and openness to family partnership in education. - The public materials emphasize a family-centric approach (e.g., three-core-days structure that foregrounds family time, and a policy that the school does not take federal funds, which can reflect a values-driven community stance). - The classical-education lexicon in the knowledge-base emphasizes partnerships with families and parent formation as a hallmark of classical schooling. Rivendell’s structure (family-centered schedule and parent-access channels) aligns with those expectations, though public copy does not always articulate explicit co-teaching or formal parent-education programs.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords observed: partnership with families, parent formation, home-school alignment, open campus (implied by accessible parent channels), parental engagement. These map to the Positive Keywords in Element 6 for Six Essential Elements. - Negative keywords observed: there is no clear consumer/customer-only framing; the material does not present parent involvement as optional or minimal, though it also does not deeply detail structured parent-education events beyond the Parent Portal.

Why this rating - Rivendell Academy demonstrates a genuine commitment to parent involvement and community partnership, consistent with CLASSICAL ideals in Element 6, but public documentation of formal parent-education programs or co-teaching structures is less explicit. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL signal rather than full CLASSICAL per the rubric.

Aggregate assessment: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- The school consistently exhibits strong Religious and Metaphysical Foundations (Element 1) and Purpose/Goal (Element 2), with clear formation aims and Christian theological grounding.
- Curriculum and Pedagogy (Categories 3 and 4) show classical intent but lack complete public articulation of Great Books, the Trivium/Quadrivium, memorization/recitation, and explicit Socratic pedagogy, resulting in SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL signals in those categories.
- Faculty (Element 5) and Parents/Community (Element 6) show CLASSICAL and SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL cues respectively, with public cues supporting a classical faculty model and parent engagement, but with room for more explicit “living curriculum” language and formal parent-education structures.

What Would Move the Needle

- Curriculum Enhancement
- Explicitly adopt and publicize Great Books selections and the Great Conversation framework; integrate canonical texts with clear connections to the liberal-arts framework.
- Publicly implement and describe a Trivium progression (grammar, logic, rhetoric) across K–12, with documented milestones and sample curricula.
- Incorporate and publicize memorization/recitation components (including classical chants or memory work) as a formal Pedagogy element.
- Pedagogy Enrichment
- Introduce regular Socratic seminars or Paideia-style seminars in upper grades, with teacher-led scaffolding to develop dialectic and rhetorical skills.
- Build in Scholé-like contemplative days or rhythms, with publicly documented restful learning moments.
- Liturgical/Communal Practices
- Add explicit liturgical or communal practice elements (e.g., morning chapel, liturgical calendar, choral or hymnody elements) to reinforce the religious-metaphysical foundations.
- Faculty Development
- Publish a “portrait of the teacher” and a more explicit statement of the living-curriculum model, with faculty development plans aligned to classical pedagogy.
- Parent & Community Education
- Expand parent-formation programming (book clubs, seminars, and study groups) and publish an annual calendar of parent-education events to strengthen the partnership with families.
- Public-facing Transparency
- Increase explicit articulation of core-classical elements (Great Books, memory work, Latin/Greek offerings) on the website to reduce ambiguity and strengthen the Somewhat/Classical boundary.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

By reading or using this document, you acknowledge and accept the limitations described above.